



The Outdoor Kitchen Planning Guide

Everything to decide before you buy a grill or lay a single block.

Work through each step and write your answers in. By the end you will be able to walk into any design or builder conversation knowing what you want and what to ask for, which is most of what separates a project that goes well from one that does not.

The measurements in Step 4 are what EagleBuilt actually builds to, not figures copied from a magazine. Where a manufacturer's installation manual or your local code says otherwise, they win. Always.

Budget figures, not quotes

Any number in this guide is a budget guide. Sites differ, access differs, and what sits under your existing patio differs. A field walk determines the final price.

From EagleBuilt AI, the free 3D outdoor kitchen design tool and the people who build them. CSLB #992251, General Contractor and C-29 Masonry.

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How will you use it?

Who you will cook for: usually how many people, and how many at a big gathering?

What you will cook: grilling, smoking, pizza, sides, full meals outside?

Seating: seats at the counter, a separate dining table, or both?

Season: year-round, or only warm months?

Your top three must-haves, before any nice-to-haves:

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Check the spot

Ten minutes standing in the space saves more money than any other ten minutes in this process.

Sun and shade at the times you actually cook:

Which way the wind usually runs. Will smoke blow at the house or the seating?

Distance to the indoor kitchen, in steps. You will walk it many times per meal.

What is overhead: roof, pergola, tree? A covered cook area usually needs a vent hood.

What is underneath: patio, pavers, deck, lawn? A masonry island is heavy.

Does water pool there after rain?

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Choose zones and appliances

Most outdoor kitchens work best split into four zones. Decide what goes in each before anything is drawn.

Hot	Grill, side burner, pizza oven, smoker, griddle
Cold	Refrigerator, ice maker, beverage centre, kegerator
Wet	Sink, with or without hot water
Dry	Prep counter and storage: drawers, doors, trash pullout

Your appliances, and the cutout size from each installation manual:

Choose the appliances first

This is the mistake that costs the most. The cutout, not the nominal size, sets the island layout. Some 30-inch grills need a 33-inch opening. Pick the equipment, confirm every cutout against its manual, then frame. Reversing that order means cutting block or reordering appliances.

4 The measurements that matter

These are EagleBuilt's build standards. Your appliance manuals and local code come first, always.

Island depth	32 inches. Takes every cutout we carry. 24 inches is a back-bar depth: no BBQ and no fridge fits it. 36 inches only where a specific component needs it.
Counter height	37 to 37.5 inches finished. The refrigerator sets this, not taste: an outdoor fridge needs 34 to 34.5 inches of clear opening underneath, and a 3 inch poured concrete slab on top lands the finished top at 37.5.
Raised bar	42 inches. Hides the grill area from guests and gives people a place to sit that is out of the cook's way.
Seating overhang	12 inch cantilever at the bar, so a stool actually fits under it.
Seat spacing	About 24 inches of bar length per seat.
Landing space	At least 12 inches of counter beside the grill. 18 to 24 inches on both sides is better.
Framing between cutouts	2 inches of structure. It is why a 32 inch grill needing a 30.6 inch opening occupies about 33 inches of island.
Walkway behind the cook	36 inches minimum. 42 to 48 if two people cook or guests pass through.

Why the fridge sets the height

It is the tallest thing that has to fit underneath. If the clear opening is less than the fridge needs, the fridge does not go in, and by then the island is built. A thinner countertop does not lower the finished height; it means the wall underneath is built taller.

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Utilities and permits

Gas, electrical and water cost far less to run before the island exists than after. This is also the work that usually triggers a permit.

Gas: natural gas line or propane? Where does the line come from?

Electrical: outlets for fridge, lights and small appliances. All outdoor outlets must be GFCI-protected.

Water: does the sink need a supply line, and where does the drain go?

Lighting: task lighting over the grill and prep, plus ambient.

Permits: call your local building department before you start. Who pulls them?

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Set a budget range

Set a range you are comfortable with, not a single number.

Total range, from and to:

Where you will splurge, usually the grill and sometimes the countertop:

Where you will save: storage, finishes, or adding appliances later:

Do not forget utilities, permits, the patio or slab underneath, and lighting. These sit outside most headline quotes.

Questions to ask a builder

Ask all of these. The answers tell you more than any portfolio.

- How many outdoor kitchens have you built? Can I see photos and speak to past clients?
- What do you frame islands with, block, steel stud or wood, and why?
- How do you support a bar overhang? Brackets, or poured monolithic with the wall?
- Does the island need an insulated grill jacket with your construction method?
- Do you pull the permits, and who does the gas and electrical work?
- Is the quote itemised, and what is specifically not included?
- What does your workmanship warranty cover, and for how long?

Two of those questions are doing real work

We build in CMU and pour the bar overhang monolithic with the wall: rebar bent out of the block, shored, poured in place, stripped at 48 hours. No brackets and no corbels. And because block with a concrete counter is non-combustible, the insulated grill jacket a wood-framed island usually needs generally is not required. Ask any builder both questions and the answers will separate them quickly.

Your next step

Take your answers into the free EagleBuilt design tool. Lay the island out in 3D with real appliance cutouts, watch a budget figure move as you build, and get plan, elevation and 3D drawings when you are done. No appointment and no salesperson.

eaglebuilt.ai/design/

Questions about your own project? Reply to any newsletter issue, or email info@eaglebuilt.ai. We read every one.